Fiscal Year:	FY 2014	**Task Last Updated:**	FY 07/15/2014
PI Name:	Turner, Russell T Ph.D.		
Project Title:	Role of Marrow Adipocytes in Bone Loss during Simulated Spaceflight		
Division Name:	Space Biology		
Program/Discipline:	SPACE BIOLOGY		
Program/Discipline--Element/Subdiscipline:	SPACE BIOLOGY--Cellular and molecular biology		
Joint Agency Name:		**TechPort:**	No
Human Research Program Elements:	None		
Human Research Program Risks:	None		
Space Biology Element:	(1) Cell & Molecular Biology (2) Animal Biology: Vertebrate		
Space Biology Cross-Element Discipline:	(1) Musculoskeletal Biology		
Space Biology Special Category:	(1) Translational (Countermeasure) Potential		
PI Email:	Russell.Turner@oregonstate.edu	**Fax:**	FY 541 737 6914
PI Organization Type:	UNIVERSITY	**Phone:**	541 737 9545
Organization Name:	Oregon State University		
PI Address 1:	Nutrition & Exercise Sciences/Skeletal Biology Laboratory		
PI Address 2:	Milam Hall, Mail Stop 107B		
PI Web Page:			
City:	Corvallis	**State:**	OR
Zip Code:	97331-8558	**Congressional District:**	4
Comments:			
Project Type:	Ground	**Solicitation / Funding Source:**	2011 Space Biology NNH11ZTT002N
Start Date:	09/15/2012	**End Date:**	09/14/2015
No. of Post Docs:		**No. of PhD Degrees:**	
No. of PhD Candidates:	1	**No. of Master' Degrees:**	
No. of Master's Candidates:		**No. of Bachelor's Degrees:**	
No. of Bachelor's Candidates:	2	**Monitoring Center:**	NASA ARC
Contact Monitor:	Smith, Jeffrey	**Contact Phone:**	650-604-0880
Contact Email:	jeffrey.d.smith2@nasa.gov		
Flight Program:			
Flight Assignment:			
Key Personnel Changes/Previous PI:	There were no changes in key personnel.		
COI Name (Institution):	Iwaniec, Urszula (Oregon State University) Wong, Carmen (Oregon State University)		
Grant/Contract No.:	NNX12AL24G		
Performance Goal No.:			
Performance Goal Text:			

Task Description:	Spaceflight, by impairing the differentiation program of stem cells residing within bone marrow results in bone loss, increased bone marrow adiposity, anemia, and impaired immune function. Because these disturbances may potentially compromise the success of long-duration flights, there exists an urgent need to identify the underlying mechanisms and implement effective countermeasures. We propose to test the novel hypothesis that negative energy balance during spaceflight results in 1) bone marrow dysfunction and increased marrow adiposity and 2) altered signaling by peripheral adipokines (cytokines produced by adipocytes) all of which, in turn, contribute to negative bone turnover balance and bone loss. The proposed research will focus on the precise role of adipose tissue and the important adipokine leptin in mediating the detrimental effects of simulated spaceflight (hindlimb unloading) on bone marrow cells in mice by accomplishing the following 2 specific aims: Specific Aim 1 will test the hypothesis that increased bone marrow adiposity plays a causal role in mediating simulated spaceflight-induced changes in bone metabolism. This will be accomplished by comparing the skeletal response to hindlimb unloading of wild type (WT) mice with mice incapable of generating bone marrow adipocytes (kit-receptor-deficient KitW/W-v mice). Specific Aim 2 will test the hypothesis that the adipokine leptin, by targeting the differentiation of bone marrow stem cells, plays a key role in mediating energy sensitive changes in bone metabolism during simulated spaceflight. This will be accomplished by examining whether transplantation of mesenchymal or hematopoietic stem cells from leptin receptor-deficient db/db mice into WT mice alters bone loss during simulated spaceflight. Completion of the proposed project is expected to increase our understanding of the role of energy metabolism in mediating bone loss during simulated spaceflight and suggest specific non-pharmacological and pharmacological interventions to mitigate the detrimental effects of spaceflight on bone marrow.
Rationale for HRP Directed Research:	
Research Impact/Earth Benefits:	Osteoporosis is a major health concern. To our knowledge, all forms of osteoporosis involve infiltration of fat into bone marrow. If the increased marrow fat contributes to bone loss, as hypothesized, this research will have significance to human health that transcends protecting astronauts from bone loss during spaceflight. Our findings suggest that hematopoietic cells inhibit transition of lining cells to osteoblasts. As such, loss of this negative regulation by hematopoietic lineage cells is a plausible mechanism for increased bone turnover following irradiation. An important implication of the putative negative regulation of bone turnover by hematopoietic lineage cells would be that restoration of normal hematopoiesis following irradiation may be essential to restore normal bone turnover. Additionally, blocking the inhibitory actions of hematopoietic cells on osteoblast differentiation may be an attractive approach toward normalizing bone formation during spaceflight. Prevention of morbid obesity in ob/ob mice further exacerbated many of the abnormalities associated with leptin deficiency. Because morbid obesity normally present in ob/ob mice attenuates the abnormal skeletal phenotype associated with leptin deficiency, the role of leptin in regulating postnatal bone growth, maturation, and turnover may have been underestimated. These findings suggest that a reduction in leptin levels due to a negative energy balance during spaceflight could contribute to bone loss in astronauts.
Task Progress:	Progress on Specific Aim 1 As described in our Year 1 Progress report, Experiment 1 was designed to evaluate differences in skeletal response of WT and adipocyte-deficient kitw/w-v mice to simulated spaceflight. The hindlimb unloading portion of the study was begun in Year 1 and completed in Year 2. Additionally progress was made in Year 2: 1) duel energy x-ray absorptiometry (DXA) measurements were performed to measure body composition and the results analyzed; 2) femur, tibia, and lumbar vertebra were scanned ex vivo by microcomputed tomography (microCT) and the 3D reconstructions analyzed for determination of bone microarchitecture; 3) serum glucose levels were measured at necropsy; and 4) femurs were embedded in plastic for sectioning and quantitative histomorphometry. Experiment 2 was designed to evaluate differences in skeletal response of WT mice to simulated spaceflight following transplantation of bone marrow from WT or kitw/w-v mice. As was pointed out in our Year 1 annual report, the radiosensitivity of mice varies among strains. We performed a pilot study to verify feasibility of transplanting hematopoietic stem cells into kitw/w-v and WT mice. Although found to be more radiosensitive, we developed a successful protocol for stem cell transplantation into the mutant mice. Progress on Specific Aim 2 Experiment 1 was designed to determine whether a high level of fat within bone marrow is associated with accelerated bone loss during simulated spaceflight. The animal portion of this study was initiated and completed during Year 2. Specifically, weanling (1-month-old) WT and leptin-deficient ob/ob mice were maintained for 3 months under thermoneutral (32ºC) housing conditions to equalize resting energy expenditure between WT and ob/ob mice. The ob/ob mice were pair-fed to the WT mice to prevent development of morbid obesity in the ob/ob mice. Additionally: 1) the hindlimb unloading portion of the study was performed; 2) DXA measurements were performed to measure body composition and the results analyzed; 3) femur, tibia, and lumbar vertebra were scanned ex vivo by miroCT and the 3D reconstructions analyzed for determination of bone microarchitecture; 3) serum glucose, P1NP (bone formation marker), osteocalcin (bone turnover marker), and corticosterone (stress hormone) levels were measured at necropsy; and 4) femurs were embedded in plastic for sectioning and quantitative histomorphometry.
Bibliography Type:	Description: (Last Updated: 01/12/2026)
Articles in Peer-reviewed Journals	Turner RT, Iwaniec UT, Wong CP, Lindenmaier LB, Wagner LA, Branscum AJ, Menn SA, Taylor J, Zhang Y, Wu H, Sibonga JD. "Acute exposure to high dose gamma-radiation results in transient activation of bone lining cells." Bone. 2013 Nov;57(1):164-73. Epub 2013 Aug 14. http://dx.doi.org/10.1016/j.bone.2013.08.002 ; PubMed PMID: 23954507; PubMed Central PMCID: PMC4042434 , Nov-2013
Articles in Peer-reviewed Journals	Turner RT, Philbrick KA, Wong CP, Olson DA, Branscum AJ, Iwaniec U. "Morbid obesity attenuates the skeletal abnormalities associated with leptin deficiency in mice." J Endocrinol. 2014 Jul 2. [Epub ahead of print] http://dx.doi.org/10.1530/JOE-14-0224 PubMed PMID: 24990938 , Jul-2014